UNDERGRADUATE RESEARCH · HOW TO

How do you choose a **research question** you will still care about in a year?

I started from the wrong place, then found my way back.

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THE USUAL START

Most students start with **the portfolio.**

A lot of people get into undergraduate research to go abroad, write the USMLE, or clear PLAB or AMC.

That is a reason to start. It is not a reason to keep going.

STEP 1 · THE QUESTION

Start from something that **bothers you.**

1 **Something you saw**

On a ward, in a clinic, on campus.

2 **One sentence**

If you cannot say it as a question, it is not ready.

3 **Check it exists**

Has someone already asked it? That is your review of literature.

MY START

Mine started **before medical college.**

I studied at PC Thomas Classes. Just before my drop year, an individual who believed in me quite a lot told me about whole-food, plant-based diets and veganism.

He talked to me about Dr. Michael Greger, Neal Barnard, and the Physicians Committee for Responsible Medicine.

MY START

I was **skeptical,** yet I listened.

He showed me Cowspiracy and Seaspiracy. A lot of it, in several instances, did not have solid scientific data behind it.

But whole-food, plant-based diets did have substance to them. I kept that close to my heart.

THE CROSSROADS

I had **enough** of NEET UG.

After my first attempt, I had enough marks for veterinary medicine or BDS, and I had decided to take whatever I got.

But what he told me about preventive medicine and nutrition got me thinking. I told my mom and dad that I wanted to give it another go.

THEN I FORGOT

I joined college and **let it go.**

I was consumed by the need to fit in, to be validated, to be understood. I discussed these ideas, and was ridiculed for a while.

COVID twice. Politics, arts, college dynamics. I forgot all the whys and hows of why I got there.

LOOKING BACK

The atmosphere did not foster **academic thinking.**

When I look back, the overall atmosphere did not foster much academic thinking or even discourse.

But all those decisions led me to where I am right now.

THE QUESTIONS CAME BACK

In second year, I **took a few steps back.**

I reanalysed what I might have always wanted to do, and I started going department by department, ward by ward.

That is where R02 starts.

TRY THIS

Before you pick a topic:

1 **Write down**

What bothered you on the ward this week.

2 **Pick one**

The one you cannot stop thinking about.

3 **Search**

Has it been asked? Read before you plan.

4 **Then talk**

Take the question, not a topic, to a professor.

Next: R02. How to run a cross-sectional study.